Hyunsup Ko

Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Political Science, Syracuse University
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Education

Ph.D. Candidate, Political Science, Syracuse University 2022 – 2027 (expected)
- Fields: International Relations (major), Security Studies (minor)
- Dissertation: *The Role of Junior Allies in Alliance Management: The U.S.–ROK Alliance and North Korea*
- Committee: Daniel McDowell (Advisor), Brian Taylor, Greg Smith

M.A., HRM and Public Administration, Université Paris II Panthéon-Assas 2014 – 2015
- Thesis: *Motivation for Sustainable Development* (written in French)

B.A., French Language and Literature, Seoul National University 2003 – 2009

Research

Research interests

Alliance politics, deterrence, foreign policy decision-making, international security, East Asian security, formal modeling, sanctions.

Working papers

"Assurance from Junior Allies: Cooperative Management of Adversaries Below the War Threshold" (Job Market Paper)
- Preparing to submit to the *Journal of Conflict Resolution*.

"Civil-Military Relations in North Korea: Dictator's Toolkit"
- Draft available upon request.

Data

U.S. and South Korean Policy Toward North Korea, 1991–2024
- Original monthly dataset coding each ally's policy separately across five instruments: economic aid, diplomacy, sanctions, rhetoric, and military posture.

Work in progress

Allied signaling and North Korean provocations in the Kim Jong Un era, 2012–2024

Rhetorical provocation in asymmetric alliances: Evidence from South Korean Ministry of Unification weekly reports

Conference presentations

"Assurance from Junior Allies: Cooperative Management of Adversaries Below the War Threshold" Sept. 2026
- American Political Science Association, Annual Meeting

"Junior Allies Can Deter Too: South Korean Rhetoric, U.S. Diplomacy, and North Korean Provocations" Apr. 2026

– New England Political Science Association, Annual Meeting

"Beyond the Patron: The Protégé's Role in Alliance Cohesion and Deterrence" Apr. 2025
– New England Political Science Association, Annual Meeting

"Policy Coherence in the US-ROK Alliance: A Hidden Answer to the North Korean Conundrum" Apr. 2024
– Midwest Political Science Association, Annual Meeting

"Policy Coherence in the US-ROK Alliance: A Hidden Answer to the North Korean Conundrum" Nov. 2023
– Political Science Research Workshop, Syracuse University

Research experience

Research Assistant to Professor Daniel McDowell Spring 2027 (expected)
Research Assistant to Professor Greg Smith Fall 2024

Policy Reports (selected)

Office of National Security, Republic of Korea. *Emerging and Core Technologies and National Security Strategic Tasks* (in Korean). Seoul. 2022
– Lead drafter (full report) and project manager.

Office of National Security, Republic of Korea. *Security Threat Outlook, 2021–2030* (in Korean). Reported to the President, expanded National Security Council ministerial meeting, March 3, 2022. 2022
– Lead drafter, economic security section.

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record

Introduction to International Relations Summer 2026

Teaching Assistant

Introduction to Political Analysis — section leader Fall 2026
Introduction to International Relations — section leader (4 semesters) 2023 – 2026
International Security Spring 2025
Fighting Crime in Latin America Spring 2024
Israeli-Palestinian Conflict Fall 2022

Guest Lectures

"Economic Sanctions and Weaponized Interdependence," International Security Apr. 2025
"Bargaining Model," Fighting Crime in Latin America Apr. 2024
"Alliance," Introduction to International Relations Nov. 2023

Additional Training

Future Professoriate Program, Syracuse University 2025 – 2027

– Two-year teaching development program. Certificate in University Teaching expected 2027.

EITM Summer Institute, University of Michigan Aug. 2025

– Selected participant; formal modeling, quantitative methods, and research design. Funded by NSF.

Professional Experience

Thirteen years as a career civil servant in Republic of Korea national security policy, spanning nuclear and deterrence policy, defense planning, and alliance relations with the United States and Europe, and culminating in an appointment to the presidential Office of National Security.

Ministry of National Defense, Republic of Korea 2009 – 2022

– Director of Public Relations; Deputy Director of Nuclear Policy; Deputy Director of Planning and Coordination; staff positions in defense reform, military structure planning, and ROK-Europe relations.

Office of National Security, Republic of Korea 2020 – 2022

– Assistant Secretary to the President, Blue House.

Ministry of Justice, France 2015

– Intern, General Secretariat Office.

Grants and Awards

The Ketcham Award, Department of Political Science, Syracuse University May 2026

– For students whose work exhibits a commitment to open and just public life

Research Assistantship Fellowship, Department of Political Science, Syracuse University Fall 2024, Spring 2027

Professional, Academic, and Creative Work Grant, Graduate Student Organization, Syracuse University 2024, 2025, 2026

Travel Grant, Department of Political Science, Syracuse University 2024, 2025, 2026

Korean Government Scholarship for graduate study in France 2014 – 2016

– Full tuition and stipend

Superior Academic Performance Scholarship, Seoul National University 2003 – 2009

– Seven semesters

Professional Honors

Citation for Exceptional Public Officer, President of the Republic of Korea Feb. 2020

Certificate of Appreciation, British Embassy Seoul Feb. 2018

– For contributions to UK-ROK defense cooperation

Citation for Armed Forces Day, Minister of National Defense Oct. 2017

51st National Higher Civil Service Examination, Republic of Korea Dec. 2007

Skills

Research methods

Formal modeling and game theory; quantitative analysis; text-as-data and content coding; web scraping; supervised text classification.

Software and languages

R, Stata, LaTeX, GitHub

Korean (native), English (fluent), French (advanced, C1), Japanese (conversational)

Updated October 12, 2026